

WHAT'S ADDICTION GOT TO DO WITH MY PROBLEMS?

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Accept responsibility for legal problems without blaming others.
2. Identify the connections between legal problems experienced and addictive behaviors.
3. Identify thought patterns that created legal difficulties.
4. Understand the need to maintain abstinence from addiction to remain free of negative consequences that include legal problems.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE LEGAL PROBLEMS

- Barriers and Solutions
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Handling Tough Situations in a Healthy Way
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- What Do I Need and How Do I Get It?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Antisocial Behavior
- Living Environment Deficiencies
- Occupational Problems
- Substance Abuse/Dependence
- Substance-Induced Disorders
- Treatment Resistance

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “What’s Addiction Got to Do with My Problems?” activity is designed to help clients to examine the connections between their addictive behaviors and their past and/or current legal issues. It is useful, when clients are assessing the consequences of their behaviors, to point out the ripple effects

of those consequences. For example, going to jail may be the primary consequence, but that in turn interferes with holding a job, which makes it harder to earn income, which in turn cuts into money needed for bills, and so on. It may be useful to use this as a group activity and allow the group to process examples and give feedback and input. Follow up may include other exercises, such as “Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior” and “Relapse Prevention Planning.”

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Some of the consequences of addiction include legal difficulties. It is important to remember that legal difficulties (jail/prison, fines, probation, and so on) tend to cause problems in other areas, including self-worth, relationships, work, and finances. It is also important to remember that taking responsibility for both our decisions that led to illegal acts and for those acts themselves is a necessary part of recovery. Neither is an easy task. Sometimes we want to blame other people, circumstances, or our addictions rather than being accountable for our own thoughts and actions. We also may not want to admit that our illegal activities are related in any way to our addictive behaviors. If we don't want to keep having legal problems, though, we have to do some things differently. This exercise will help you look at your legal problems, the painful consequences you've experienced, the patterns that have led to your breaking the law or not accepting responsibility, and strategies for avoiding legal difficulties in recovery.

1. In the left-hand column, list your legal history including past and current legal issues. In the right-hand column, list how the illegal behavior is related to addictive behavior. Keep in mind that the relationship may be direct (e.g., was high when stole a car, stole money from work to continue gambling) or indirect (e.g., stole money to pay bills, which went unpaid due to gambling behavior).

Legal Problems**Relationship to Addiction**

_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

2. What are the consequences you've experienced as a result of legal difficulties? List all the types of unpleasant results you've suffered due to the legal problem listed in question 1.

3. How have you tried to deny your actions or to blame something or someone else for your current or past legal problems?

4. What thoughts helped you support or justify engaging in illegal activities?

5. For each thought you've identified in question 4, how did it support your illegal activities?

6. How will continued addictive behavior complicate your current legal difficulties or those legal difficulties that remain unresolved?

7. Listed in the left-hand column is a sample of prosocial behaviors. In the right-hand column, please identify ways you can practice each in your recovery efforts. Be specific. For example, for *honesty*, be more specific than "telling the truth"—describe how you will be honest in a specific situation where you have been dishonest in the past.

Prosocial Behaviors

I will practice . . .

Honesty

Helping others

Reliability

Consistency

Dependability

Acting responsibly

Respecting rules even if I disagree with them

8. What do you foresee as the biggest obstacle in preventing future legal problems?

9. List at least five strategies for meeting your social, emotional, and financial needs in recovery without resorting to criminal activity or addictive behavior.

Be sure to bring this activity with you to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about questions, thoughts, and feelings about the exercise.